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Making sense of the world

THE WEEK

Junior

THE BEST MAGAZINE FOR CURIOUS KIDS

Brenna Huckaby
Snowboarding

Johannes Aigner
Alpine Skiing

Declan Farmer
Ice Hockey

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Nordic Skiing & Biathlon

LET'S GO!

The winter action at the Milan Cortina Paralympics is about to begin **p12**



This week's big news

FACT FILE

US Supreme Court justices are nominated by the President, confirmed by the Senate, and appointed for life.



The US Supreme Court building in Washington, DC

Symbol of the court



The Supreme Court's seal is the same as the Great Seal of the US except for the addition of a star beneath the eagle's claws. This symbolizes the existence of a single Supreme Court. The current seal is the fifth version to be used in the court's history and is stamped on official papers.

Supreme Court rules on tariffs

On February 20, the US Supreme Court (the nation's highest court of law) issued a ruling that rejected the tariffs imposed by President Donald Trump. Tariffs are taxes on goods brought into the US from other countries.

What was the controversy?

Traditionally, only Congress (branch of government that makes laws) has the authority to set tariffs. Soon after taking office last year, however, Trump used an emergency law from the 1970s to impose tariffs on dozens of countries without involving Congress. He wanted to make it so costly to bring goods into the US that companies would make their products here instead, creating jobs for Americans. While the tariffs have brought in about \$175 billion, many economic experts say they have created a financial burden for Americans. That is because other countries pass on the cost of the tariffs to US companies that buy goods from them, and those companies then charge consumers more for the products. In April 2025, a group of small businesses, led by a toy maker in Illinois, and 12 states challenged the tariffs in court, saying Trump did not have the authority to impose them. Lower courts agreed with them, but the White House appealed those rulings all the way to the Supreme Court.

What was the decision?

The Supreme Court's nine judges, called justices, voted 6–3 to reject Trump's use of the emergency law. Chief Justice John Roberts wrote the opinion and was joined by Amy Coney Barrett, Neil Gorsuch, Ketanji Brown Jackson, Elena Kagan, and Sonia Sotomayor. Justices Samuel Alito Jr. Brett Kavanaugh, and Clarence Thomas dissented (opposed the decision). Roberts wrote that the 1970s law does not give Trump the authority to "unilaterally impose tariffs of unlimited amount, duration, and scope." The decision invalidated a wide range of tariffs Trump established last year.

Why is the ruling significant?

The landmark decision was the first big Supreme Court ruling against Trump in his second term and was widely seen as a check on his efforts to expand Presidential power. Trump has often used tariffs to pressure other countries to do what he wants, and this limits his ability to do that. The ruling will also affect the global economy. The tariffs have strained relationships between the US and other countries, including important trading partners like Canada and India. Many countries have had to change how they do business and find new trading partners, and now they will have to adapt again.



John Roberts

How did people react?

Trump said the ruling was "deeply disappointing" and "ridiculous" and that the justices lacked "the courage to do what's right for our country." He also said he would use a different law to impose tariffs. Many elected officials and business leaders cheered the decision. "This is a win for the wallets of every American consumer. Trump's chaotic and illegal tariff tax made life more expensive and our economy more unstable," said Chuck Schumer, the leading Democrat in the US Senate. "We were standing for something very important," said Rick Woldenberg, owner of the toy company that started the lawsuit. "We're excited to stand on the right side of history here." A new poll by ABC News, *The Washington Post*, and Ipsos found that 64% of Americans oppose the tariffs.

What will happen next?

Supreme Court rulings are final and cannot be appealed. The court did not say whether the government will have to repay the money it received from tariffs to companies or consumers. Those decisions will likely be made through other legal actions. On February 23, FedEx filed a lawsuit against the government seeking refunds of the extra money it paid because of the tariffs, and more companies are expected to do the same. Economists said the court's decision is unlikely to have a significant effect on prices for consumers.



Holy month of Ramadan starts

Around the world, nearly 2 billion Muslims are celebrating the holy month of Ramadan, which began on February 17 in the US. Muslims, who follow the religion of Islam, believe it was during Ramadan in the year 610 when Allah (God) first revealed verses of the Quran (Islamic religious text) to Islam's founder, the Prophet Muhammad.

Ramadan is a time of reflection and prayer. People give to charity, visit mosques (places of worship), fast (do not eat or drink) during the day, and share meals called suhoor before dawn and iftar after sunset. Ramadan ends with Eid al-Fitr, a three-day festival of prayers, meals, and gifts.

Festivities will include torchlight parades in Indonesia and free meals at mosques in Malaysia. In Australia, Muslims will dine with people of other faiths. In Ohio, there will be suhoor feasts. However, many people say Ramadan will feel somber this year due to the war in Gaza, where nearly 99% of people are Muslim. "We are working hard to restore our smiles and bring Ramadan back to its celebratory form," a man in Gaza told PBS News.



A meal during Ramadan



The closing ceremony

PLANET FRIENDLY

The venues for the 2026 Winter Olympics were almost entirely powered by renewable electricity.

Winter Olympics come to a close

The 2026 Milan Cortina Games ended on February 22 with a ceremony titled "Beauty in Action" at the Verona Arena in Italy. About 12,000 people filled the 2,000-year-old amphitheater, and millions more watched on TV or online.

The Parade of Athletes featured nearly 3,000 competitors from more than 90 nations, with women's hockey captain Hilary Knight and figure skater Evan Bates carrying the US flag. A light show and glitter cannons appeared above a central stage shaped like a waterdrop to symbolize Italy's mountains, rivers, and seas.

Performers included Italian DJ Gabry Ponte and American electronic music group Major Lazer. Following tradition, the Olympic flag was presented to France, host of the 2030 Winter Games, and the Olympic flame was extinguished.

Norway left the Games with 41 medals, the highest total of any nation. Norwegian cross-country skier Johannes Høsflot Klæbo won six gold medals and now has the most golds from a single Winter Olympics and the most Winter Olympic golds of all time, with 11.

Other historic moments included Alpine skier Sarah Schleper of Mexico competing alongside her 18-year-old son, Lasse Gaxiola, marking the first time a mother and son have taken part in the same Winter Olympics. And in the most gender-balanced Winter Games to date, women made up 47% of the competitors.

Team USA finished second in the medal count with a total of 33, including 12 golds, while Brazil and Georgia earned their first Winter Olympic medals. For more on the Games, see page 18.



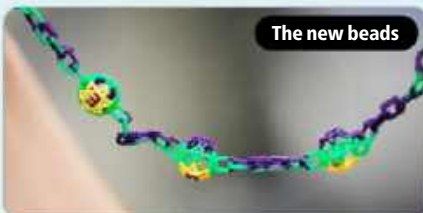
IT'S AN AMAZING WEEK FOR...

A LONG LIFE

A sea cow named Romeo has been verified as the world's oldest manatee. His keepers at a Florida aquarium don't know his exact age because he was born in the wild but say he's at least 71 and loves lettuce and daily naps.



Romeo



The new beads

GOING GREEN

Plastic bead necklaces are a traditional part of the annual Mardi Gras festival in New Orleans, Louisiana, but every year, 25 million pounds of beads go in the trash. To reduce waste this year, scientists 3D-printed biodegradable beads containing okra seeds that can be planted.

MAKING FRIENDS

A baby macaque monkey named Punch and his stuffed orangutan have gone viral. Videos showed the little guy, who lives at a zoo in Japan, hugging the toy after being rejected by other monkeys. Now, though, the zoo says Punch is making progress within the troop and "getting groomed, playfully poking at others."



Punch and his stuffy



National news

DID YOU KNOW?

Since 1964, the average length of a US President's annual address has been between 35 and 85 minutes.



President Donald Trump speaking in the House Chamber of the US Capitol building in Washington, DC

Who is Abigail Spanberger?



In 2025, Abigail Spanberger (above) became the first woman to be elected governor of Virginia. She pledged to increase job opportunities and lower the cost of living. Previously, she represented Virginia in the US House of Representatives and was an officer in the Central Intelligence Agency.

State of the Union speech delivered

President Donald Trump delivered the State of the Union address at the US Capitol building on February 24. The Constitution (highest US law) requires the President to give an annual message to Congress (branch of government that makes laws), reporting on issues facing the nation.

What happened?

Trump, a Republican, spoke for 108 minutes, the longest speech a President has given to Congress, breaking his own record of 100 minutes in 2025. Vice President JD Vance and Speaker of the House of Representatives Mike Johnson sat behind him. Members of Congress, the President's cabinet (top advisers), and four of the nine US Supreme Court justices were in the audience. Guests invited by Trump and other lawmakers also attended.

What did the President say?

Trump said that after inheriting "a nation in crisis" when he took office last year, he had brought the US back to a "golden age" and the economy is now "roaring like never before." He said he had driven down the prices of goods and services to make life more affordable for Americans, reduced crime and illegal immigration, and helped end wars around the world. He also presented medals to some of his guests, including Medals of Honor to a current and a former member of the military.

What was the Democratic response?

Virginia Governor Virginia Spanberger gave the response on behalf of the Democrats. In a 12-minute speech, she said that under Trump's leadership, the cost of living had soared for

Americans. "We did not hear the truth from our President," she said. Alex Padilla, a US senator from California, gave another response in Spanish. He said Trump's immigration policies led to unnecessary violence and his false claims that US elections are fraudulent threatened our democracy.

How did people react?

Republican officials, such as Rick Allen, a lawmaker from Georgia, applauded the speech. Trump is "bringing the American dream back for working families," he said. In an unusual move, many Democratic officials skipped the speech to attend a protest called the People's State of the Union. One of them, Yassamin Ansari, a Democrat from Arizona, said she didn't attend because she knew "we would not hear an accurate state of our union."



WORD OF THE WEEK

PIANO

In the 18th century, a musical instrument was invented that allowed players to regulate the length and volume of their musical notes with a set of pedals. The invention was given the name "pianoforte" because in Italian *piano* means "soft" and *forte* means "loud." "Pianoforte" was eventually shortened to "piano."

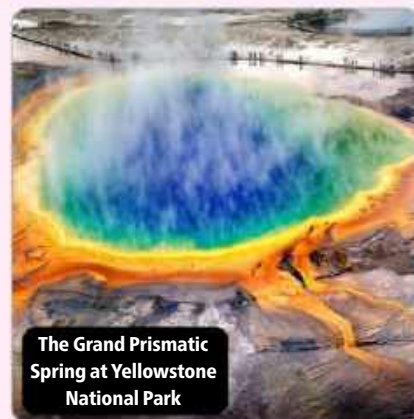


THE WEEK IN HISTORY

March 1, 1872

First national park is established

On March 1, 1872, President Ulysses S. Grant signed legislation to create Yellowstone National Park, the world's first national park, in the states of present-day Wyoming, Montana, and Idaho. The law banned development in the area and ensured it would be "for the benefit and enjoyment of the people." Today there are 63 US national parks visited by millions of people each year.



The Grand Prismatic Spring at Yellowstone National Park



The rocket

Artemis rocket needs repairs

NASA, the US space agency, has announced that the Artemis II rocket will be moved off the launch pad at the Kennedy Space Center in Florida to fix a helium supply problem. The repair will delay the launch of the Artemis II mission to the Moon from March to at least April. Once the mission launches, the crew of three US astronauts and one Canadian will spend 10 days circling the Moon and traveling farther into space than humans ever have.



A view of the park

California state park expands

Big Basin Redwoods, California's oldest state park, has expanded by 153 acres, state officials said. The acquired land, known as NoraBella, in Boulder Creek, will serve as a new entrance for the 18,376-acre park. The Sempervirens Fund, a conservation group, sold the land to the state for about \$2.4 million. Officials hope the expansion will help restore the park after being damaged by wildfires in 2020.



Michelle Yeoh

Trailblazing actress gets a star

Michelle Yeoh, age 63, has been honored with a star on the Hollywood Walk of Fame in Los Angeles, California. Yeoh has appeared in more than 70 feature films and television projects. In 2023, she made history as the first Asian performer to win the Academy Award for Best Actress. Recently, she also played Madame Morrible in *Wicked* and *Wicked: For Good*.



Central Park in New York City

SNUG IN THE SNOW

Because snow is made up of 95% trapped air, it can provide insulation to animals who burrow in it to stay warm in winter.

Blizzard blasts Northeast states

On February 22 and 23, a major storm struck the Northeast, from Maryland to Maine, dumping more than 2 feet of snow in at least five states and causing high wind gusts. It was the biggest snowstorm in history for Providence, Rhode Island, which recorded 37.9 inches of snow.

The National Weather Service classified the storm as a bomb cyclone, which happens when a storm's pressure falls by a certain amount within a 24-hour period, often due to the collision of cold Arctic air and warmer air. The weather service also issued a blizzard warning for more than 40 million people. A blizzard occurs when wind gusts of more than 35 mph last for at least three hours, causing little to no visibility.

More than 588,000 customers, many in Massachusetts and New Jersey, lost power. Utility crews worked to restore electricity, but high winds delayed their efforts. The weather service also received dozens of reports of downed trees due to the wind gusts.

In New York City, a full travel ban was in place during the worst of the storm, closing all streets, highways, and bridges except to emergency vehicles. Connecticut and Rhode Island issued similar travel restrictions to keep people safe. More than 10,000 flights were canceled, and hundreds more were delayed. New Jersey Transit suspended all trains and buses, while bus service was halted in Philadelphia, Pennsylvania.

All public schools in New York City and Boston, Massachusetts, canceled classes on February 23, while Philadelphia schools held online learning. Some schools remained closed on the days after that as roads were still being cleared.

When *The Week Junior* went to press on February 25, cities were continuing to remove snow and crews were working to fully restore electricity. More winter weather was predicted for later in the week for some areas in the Northeast, potentially complicating cleanup efforts.



People digging out cars in Philadelphia

THE WEEK'S SILLIEST HEADLINE

"Escaped pig breaks into North Carolina home in search of snacks" UPI





Around the world



José María Balcázar



Peru

Temporary leader takes over

José María Balcázar has been named Peru's ninth president in 10 years. Four of the country's last eight leaders were removed from power, and two resigned. Lawmakers appointed Balcázar to the position after the previous president, José Jerí, was accused of secretly meeting a Chinese businessman who was under investigation. Balcázar will hold office for a few months until the country votes to elect a new leader.



A Galápagos giant tortoise



Floreana Island, Ecuador

Giant tortoises reintroduced

Galápagos giant tortoises have made a comeback on Floreana Island after more than 170 years. Floreana's native subspecies was believed to be extinct, but in 2008 scientists discovered tortoises with Floreana ancestry on a nearby island. Experts bred hundreds of hatchlings and released 158 young tortoises on Floreana on February 20. "They'll literally reshape the island," one expert told *BBC Wildlife Magazine*.



Social media apps are banned.



Gabon

Total ban on social media

Gabon's government has banned social media until further notice, saying it spreads false information and is a risk to national security. Some people say the decision is an attempt to stop protesters from using social media to organize demonstrations. Recently, unrest has grown over the country's high cost of living, low pay, and poor working conditions.



Barcelona, Spain

Gaudí design is confirmed

New research has confirmed that an unusual house in the mountains near Barcelona was a work by famous Spanish architect Antoni Gaudí (1852–1926). Gaudí is known for designs inspired by nature. The building, known as Xalet del Catllaràs, was constructed between 1901 and 1908 to house workers from nearby coal mines.



Xalet del Catllaràs



Springs, South Africa

Gold rush in town

The small town of Springs was overrun by gold hunters after news spread that the precious metal had been found there. Springs once had several gold mines, but they closed years ago. Recently, a resident said he had discovered gold nuggets in a cow field, so dozens of people began digging there in the hope of finding more. Authorities arrested three people for illegal mining and brought in equipment to fill in the holes.

Searching for gold



GETTY IMAGES (7); ALAMY; SHUTTERSTOCK; VISIT SWEDEN

Around the world



Islands in Sweden

Sweden Island giveaway

The tourism organization Visit Sweden is holding a contest to “give away” five small Swedish islands for one year. Sweden has 267,570 islands—more than any other country in the world. Five winners will receive a certificate and the right to use their island as they wish—which could involve boating, camping, and inviting guests—for a year.



A robot performance

China Dancing robots on display

About 677 million people watched as dancing robots dazzled the world during a televised Chinese Spring Festival gala. The robots spun, jumped, backflipped, and performed kung fu martial arts alongside human children. Experts say the performance was created to show the world how advanced China’s technology is. They believe it must have taken hundreds of training sessions for the robots to succeed at the routines.



Yoon Suk Yeol

Seoul, South Korea Prison sentence for former president

Yoon Suk Yeol, South Korea’s former president, has been sentenced to life in prison for leading an attempt to take over the government. In December 2024, he shocked the country by declaring martial law (military rule). Yoon claimed he did this to protect the nation, but the judge said his actions harmed the country. Yoon’s lawyers say he has appealed the sentence, so the case will now be sent to a special panel at a higher court.



Members of the company

Australia Indigenous performers win award

Bangarra Dance Theatre won the Golden Lion award for Lifetime Achievement from the 2026 Venice Biennale cultural exhibition. The company is made up of dancers from the first groups of people to inhabit Australia. This honor recognizes their 35-year contribution to dance with work that incorporates the groups’ stories. The award will be presented in Venice, Italy, this summer.

Nonthaburi, Thailand Police use creative disguise

Thai police went undercover in a traditional lion costume to catch a burglar. The man was accused of stealing objects worth about \$64,000. Officers had tried to arrest him, but he always escaped. A lion dance was taking place during celebrations for the Lunar New Year at a temple in Nonthaburi. Police wore the costume to gradually get closer to the suspect before jumping out and arresting him.



A lion dance



The big debate

Is doing nothing good for you?

Some people say it's important to take a break from being busy all the time.

What you need to know

- The term "brain rot" was coined in 1854 by naturalist Henry David Thoreau to describe a preference for simple ideas over complex ones.
- "Brain rot" was the 2024 Oxford Dictionary Word of the Year, defined as the negative impact of too much social media or online content.
- The "default mode network" (DMN) in the brain is activated when we aren't focused on a specific task. This "inner mind" is said to be related to daydreaming and imagination.



DID YOU KNOW?

A study of 2,000 kids ages 3 to 12 found that it took them an average of 33 minutes to get bored.

Modern life is full of distractions, with few opportunities to sit and think or simply gaze out the window. More often than not, every minute of our day is filled with something to do and somewhere to be, whether it's going to class or practice, doing homework, scrolling on our devices, or talking to family and friends. Many doctors and scientists say it's important to stop being so busy and make time to do nothing once in a while. A chunk of time without any planned activities can help us look inward, find calm and relaxation, and just be. But others call this "boredom" and say it's bad for us. What do you think? Is doing nothing good for you?

Yes—give me a break

Our brains are busy! They focus on so many different things throughout the day, and just like our bodies, they need a break from constant stimulation. A break isn't scrolling on our phones, watching videos, and brain rotting though. Studies show that constant distraction like that can actually cause anxiety or unhappiness, rather than be restorative. Instead, experts say, the best thing we can do is be "bored" in a good way. That doesn't mean being lazy or wasting time. It means letting our minds wander, staring at the ceiling, or gazing off into the distance. This leads to deeper thought, creative ideas, and a greater sense of purpose.

No—there's no time to waste

Doing nothing leads to a cycle of more doing nothing. The fact is that when you aren't busy, you can start to feel down or even lazy—which in turn makes you feel even less motivated. Being busy and productive keeps our brains alert and boosts our mood. Doing nothing can also mean sitting around a lot. A lack of physical activity is bad for us and increases the risk of developing health problems. Besides, there are only so many hours in the day and there's so much to do in life! We don't necessarily have to fill every minute with activities, but it's a shame to waste too much time sitting around.

YES

Three reasons doing nothing is good for you

- 1 Like our bodies, our brains are busy and need time to unwind and recharge.
- 2 Constantly distracting ourselves by staying busy or scrolling on our phones can be bad for our mental health.
- 3 When we allow our minds to wander, creative ideas start flowing and we experience a greater sense of purpose.

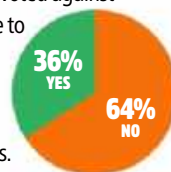
NO

Three reasons doing nothing is not good for you

- 1 Once you start doing nothing, it's hard to stop. You can lose even more motivation and end up accomplishing less and less.
- 2 Doing nothing can mean cutting back on physical activity, which can be bad for our long-term health.
- 3 Time is precious, and we shouldn't squander it by sitting around.

LAST WEEK'S POLL

Last week, we asked if extra tourist fees are a good idea. Most of you voted against paying more to see popular sites: 64% said no, and 36% said yes.



What do you think?

Now that you've read a bit more about this issue, visit kids.theweekjunior.com/polls so you can vote in our debate. Vote **YES** if you think doing nothing is good for you or **NO** if you don't. We'll publish the results next week.

The goal of the big debate is to present two sides of an issue fairly in order to stimulate discussion and allow our readers to make up their minds. The views on this page do not reflect those of *The Week Junior*, and the page is not funded by third parties.



A life in the arts

Director Steven Spielberg has achieved an entertainment milestone.

On February 1, filmmaker Steven Spielberg earned his first Grammy Award, winning Best Music Film as a producer on the documentary *Music by John Williams*. That made him an EGOT—a rare designation for someone who has won Emmy (TV), Grammy (music), Oscar (film), and Tony (theater) awards.

Spielberg was born in Cincinnati, Ohio. He began making short films on his 8mm (a vintage handheld camera) as a teen and rose to fame with hits like *Jaws* (1975) and *E.T. the Extra-Terrestrial* (1982). His more than 35 films, known for strong storytelling and memorable characters, range from war epics to musicals.

The journey to EGOT status began in 1994 when Spielberg won Oscars for Best Director and Best Picture, as a producer, for

the film *Schindler's List*. He earned another Oscar for Best Director in 1999 for *Saving Private Ryan*. He has also won four Emmys, beginning in 1996 for an animated holiday special and later for the miniseries *Band of Brothers*, *Taken*, and *The Pacific*. In 2022,

Spielberg earned a Tony as a producer of the Broadway musical *A Strange Loop*.

Music by John Williams spotlights composer John Williams, known for iconic film scores and his longtime partnership with Spielberg on 29 films. After the Grammy win, Spielberg said the recognition was “deeply meaningful.”

A few years prior to this, he reflected on his career in an interview with CBS. “Every one of my movies is a personal movie,” Spielberg said. “I don’t make films that I don’t consider to have something of myself left behind in them.”



Steven Spielberg

WOW!
As a producer, Steven Spielberg holds the record for the most nominations for Best Picture in Oscar history, with 14.

Soccer legend retires

Crystal Dunn announced her retirement from professional soccer. She made her USWNT (US Women’s National Team) debut in 2013 and won the 2019 FIFA Women’s World Cup, an Olympic bronze medal in 2021, and an Olympic gold in 2024. Dunn played for many NWSL (National Women’s Soccer League) clubs and top European teams. She also broke barriers as one of the few star Black players in women’s soccer, co-founding the Black Women’s Player Collective. Dunn said she plans to find new ways to contribute to the sport.



Crystal Dunn



Veerabhadran Ramanathan

A top science honor

Climate scientist Veerabhadran Ramanathan has received the 2026 Crafoord Prize in Geosciences, one of the highest scientific honors, for research that reshaped the understanding of global warming. He grew up in India and moved to the US to study at age 26. While working at NASA in the 1970s, he discovered that chemicals used in household products were powerful greenhouse gases damaging the ozone layer. That led to the 1987 Montreal Protocol agreement, which phased out those chemicals. Today, he is a professor at the Scripps Institution of Oceanography in California.

OVERHEARD



“There’s nothing that you can’t dream up.”

Singer-songwriter Alicia Keys on the message behind her Tony-winning musical *Hell’s Kitchen*, which is now on a global tour



HORSE HISTORY
Experts say that humans started riding horses more than 4,000 years ago.

A horse may react to the feelings it senses.

Horses can smell a person's fear

A new study has found evidence that horses can smell fear in humans' sweat and that it causes them to feel the same emotion.

People have believed for many years that horses can "smell fear," and riders are often told to relax in order to keep their horse calm. Past studies have found that horses pick up human emotions from our facial expressions and voices. Recently, a team of researchers set out to see if horses can detect people's emotions from smell alone.

In the study, 30 people were asked to watch video clips of happy scenes while cotton pads under their arms collected their sweat. Then, with new pads under their arms, they watched a scary film.

The researchers then divided 43 horses into three groups. The animals wore devices called muzzles that fit over their nose and mouth. One group was given a muzzle with a pad of happy sweat in it, one group received a pad from the scared people, and the third group had a clean, untouched pad.

The team tested the horses to see how they reacted to unexpected events, such as an umbrella being opened near them or an unfamiliar object being placed in front of them. Horses that wore the "fear" muzzle acted more scared. Their hearts beat faster, they were more likely to startle, and they were less likely to be curious about the new object or approach humans.



Staying calm can help a horse relax.

"The fearful odors from humans amplify the reactions of horses," lead study author Plotine Jardat told CNN. "The significance is that horses can smell how we feel, even if they can't hear or see us."

The researchers hope that understanding horses' emotions better can help people interact

more positively with the animals and improve horse health and happiness. Stressed or scared horses often react with behavior that can be dangerous, such as kicking or running away, so knowing the importance of remaining calm can also keep humans safer around these sensitive creatures.

The specialized nose of a horse



Horses are a prey animal—in the wild, other animals hunt them. One thing that helps them survive is a very good sense of smell, which enables them to sniff out predators before they are attacked. Horses have a structure in their nose called a Jacobson's organ that helps them pick up the scents of other animals and each other.

Unlike humans, horses can breathe only through their noses. Huffing breaths and flaring their nostrils are two of the ways the animals communicate. But horses' snouts do more than breathe and smell. They are full of nerves and covered in whiskers that allow them to "feel" what they touch, like fingers.



SWELL SHELLS

Tortoise shells contain nerve endings that enable the animal to feel something that touches its shell.



A desert tortoise

Roads closed to protect desert tortoises

Dirt roads in the Mojave Desert in California are being closed to protect an endangered tortoise. The species' survival was at risk from habitat destruction and vehicle collisions.

The desert tortoise, which lives mostly in the southwestern US, is considered threatened under the California Endangered Species Act. Since 1950, their population has declined by about 90%. In 2019, the Bureau of Land Management approved the West Mojave Route Network Project, opening nearly 6,000 miles of trails

to off-road vehicles. As the vehicles pass through the desert, some have killed tortoises and damaged their habitat.

Several groups sued to stop the project from harming local wildlife, especially the desert tortoise. A judge has now ruled that off-road vehicles are prohibited from using more than 2,200 miles of these routes. Experts hope this will help create a safe space for the turtles to thrive. Lisa Belenky from the Center for Biological Diversity said the new protection "will give them a chance to make a comeback."

Animal of the week

Flat-headed cat



For the first time in almost 30 years, a flat-headed cat has been spotted in a forest in southern Thailand. One of the world's smallest and rarest species of cats, they have webbed feet that help them swim and catch fish.

- **LIFESPAN:** 14 years in captivity
- **HABITAT:** Wetlands and forests in Southeast Asia
- **SIZE:** About 27 inches long, including the tail
- **DIET:** Crabs, fish, and frogs
- **FUN FACT:** They have been seen dunking their food in water, most likely to clean it.



Good week / Bad week



Clean energy

Ten European countries have agreed to work together to build wind farms in the North Sea in the 2030s. The goal is to make enough electricity to power 143 million homes and become the world's largest reservoir of clean energy.



Patagonia

Wildfires in Argentina burned more than 100,000 acres of native forest and threatened 2,600-year-old trees in Los Alerces National Park. A study found that global warming made the event three times more likely to occur.



Ron Magill
Wildlife expert,
Zoo Miami

"Why do some birds have such vibrant feathers?"

Salvatore, 11, New York

Feathers can play an important role in attracting a mate. In many species, including peacocks, birds of paradise, and hummingbirds, the male has vibrant feathers to capture the females' attention. Females are often less vibrant to avoid the attention of predators that might eat the eggs they lay.



A peacock

Do you have a question for an animal expert? Send it to hello@theweekjunior.com. Find out more about Zoo Miami at zoomiami.org.



Let the next Games

Get set for action at the global winter sports competition.

From March 6 to March 15, elite athletes will gather to compete in 79 medal events across six sports at the 2026 Paralympic Winter Games in Milan and Cortina, Italy. Para athletes have impairments that may be physical (affecting the body's shape or movement), visual (affecting the ability to see), or intellectual (affecting thinking or communication). Here's what you can expect at the Winter Games.

History of the Games

Sports for athletes with impairments have existed for more than 100 years. They became more prominent after soldiers returned from World War II (1939–1945) with injuries. In 1948, during the London Olympics, UK doctor Ludwig Guttman held an archery competition nearby for athletes who used wheelchairs. That event developed into the Paralympics. The first official Paralympics took place in Rome, Italy, in the summer of 1960, and the first Winter Paralympics were held in Sweden in 1976. They now take place every four years in the same cities as the Olympics.



The first Winter Games

Who can participate?



Cross-country skiing

The Paralympics recognizes 10 kinds of impairments: visual, intellectual, and eight physical impairments. The different types of physical impairments can include reduced muscle power, missing all or parts of limbs, and limited range of movement. Athletes are also assigned classifications based on how much their impairments affect their ability to perform their sport. This helps ensure that athletes are competing against others with similar abilities and that results are based on skill and mastery of the sport. Before the Games, athletes compete in tournaments to qualify for a spot representing their country on the biggest stage.

Dedan Farmer



Elisabeth (left) and Veronika Aigner



This year's Games

The 2026 Games mark the 50th anniversary of the first Paralympic Winter Games. It is Italy's second time as host. The Paralympics' mascot is Milo (type of small mammal) who was without one paw and learned to use his tail to walk and run. The opening ceremony will unfold at the Verona Arena, a historic amphitheater and a UNESCO World Heritage Site.



Paralympic sports

There will be six Para sports at this year's Games—Alpine skiing, biathlon, cross-country skiing, ice hockey, snowboard, and wheelchair curling.

In Alpine and cross-country skiing, many athletes use specially made skis to suit their abilities, such as skis equipped with chairs for athletes who need to stay seated. Skiers with vision impairments may compete with the aid of a guide. Alpine skiers compete in

different disciplines such as downhill and slalom, a type of skiing done on short courses with many turns. Team USA newcomer Audrey Crowley specializes



Ice hockey



begin!



FUN FACT

The Paralympic logo is called the Agitos, which is Latin for "I move."



Oyuna Uranchimeg



Noah Elliott

BIG EVENT

As many as 665 athletes may participate in this year's Winter Paralympics.



Audrey Crowley

in both disciplines. Para snowboarders also use specially made equipment. The snowboarding competition features banked slalom, in which each athlete races a winding course to achieve the best time, and snowboard cross, which has multiple athletes riding on a course at the same time.

Para ice hockey features athletes with a lower-body impairment. Players skate on sleds with ice blades and use two sticks to maneuver around the ice and strike the puck. In wheelchair curling, athletes push a stone with their hands or a stick toward a target.

This year's Games will feature mixed doubles competition in wheelchair curling for the first time.

Who to watch

Team USA standout **Oksana Masters** is the most decorated US Winter Paralympian of all time, with 14 medals, and is also a decorated Summer Paralympian. She will be back for glory in Nordic skiing and biathlon. Another US competitor to watch in Nordic skiing is four-time medalist **Jake Adicoff**.

Other stars chasing new heights are the **Aigner siblings** from Austria. The Aigner family, which includes skiers **Johannes**, **Veronika**, and **Barbara**, who have visual impairments, and their older sister and guide **Elisabeth**, won nine medals in Alpine skiing at the 2022 Paralympics. Italy's **Giacomo**



Oksana Masters



Jake Adicoff



Giacomo Bertagnolli



Brenna Huckaby



Jen Lee

Bertagnolli, who has eight medals in Alpine skiing, hopes to make the host nation proud.

In snowboarding, Team USA will have fierce competitors **Brenna Huckaby**, **Mike Schultz**, and **Noah Elliott**.

China will compete for its third gold in wheelchair curling with help from star **Wang Haitao**. Meanwhile, US wheelchair curler **Oyuna Uranchimeg**

returns to the Games aiming for her first medal in the sport.

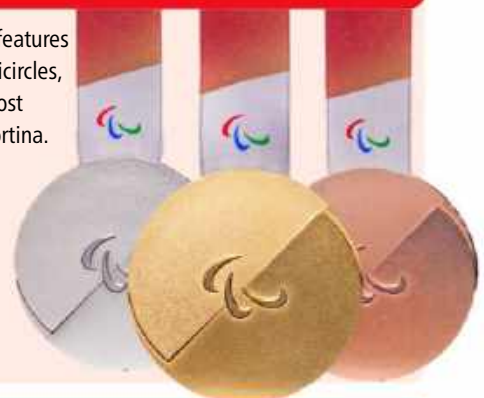
Team USA is the defending ice hockey champion, and stars **Josh Pauls**, **Declan Farmer**, and goalkeeper **Jen Lee** hope to earn the US its fifth straight gold.

How to watch

More than 80 hours of television coverage of the Paralympics will be shown across NBC, the USA Network, and CNBC. The Games will also be live streamed on [NBCSports.com](https://www.nbcsports.com), the NBC Sports app, and the streaming service Peacock. All Paralympic events will have closed captioning. Audio description of the action will also be available.

The medals

The medal design features two mirroring semicircles, representing the host cities Milan and Cortina. In the center is the Agitos, the symbol of the Paralympics. The medals are made with energy from renewable resources.





Science and technology

**COLD,
DRY LAND**
Although it's covered in ice,
Antarctica is the world's
largest desert and receives
about 6 inches of
snow per year.



Secrets of an icy continent

A team of researchers has created a map of Antarctica revealing thousands of never-before-seen hills, ridges, and valleys under the ice that covers its surface. This new information could help scientists understand how the changing climate will affect the continent.

Antarctica is the size of the US and Mexico combined. Most of it is covered in a layer of ice that's three miles thick in some places, which makes it difficult to see the shape of the land underneath. The new map has changed that.

In the past, scientists used radar from air and ground surveys to determine what the surface of the land might look like. Radar sends out radio waves, which bounce off the ground and get reflected back. Based on how long it takes the waves to bounce back, researchers can determine how far away the land is beneath the ice. This method can reveal hills, valleys, and plains, but there were often major distances between the areas that had been surveyed. That left scientists to attempt to fill in the gaps.

To create the new map, the team used satellite images, surveys of the surface ice, and

an understanding of how ice moves. Although ice behaves differently than water, the scientists were able to figure out how the ice had flowed, which helped them pinpoint the mountains and valleys underneath it. "It's a little bit like if you're kayaking in a river and there are rocks underneath the water," said Helen Ockenden from the

University Grenoble Alpes in France, the study's lead author. "Sometimes there are eddies in the surface, which can tell you about the rocks under the water." (Eddies are swirls of water.)

Mapping the land underneath Antarctica is important. The continent is losing ice as the planet warms. As the ice melts, it falls into the ocean, raising

global sea levels. Scientists are not sure how much ice the continent will lose in the future and how this will raise sea levels. The shape of a landscape affects how quickly ice moves across its surface and the speed at which it pushes up sea levels.

Experts say the map will offer more insight into what will happen in the future. "It's like before you had a grainy pixel film camera, and now you've got a properly zoomed-in digital image of what's really going on," Ockenden told BBC News.



Emperor penguins live on the ice in Antarctica.

The past frozen in time



The Thwaites Glacier in Antarctica

Information about Earth's past climate is locked within Antarctica's ice. Snowflakes contain chemicals from the atmosphere and pollen from plants and dust, among other things. The snowflakes land and, as more snow falls on top of them, gradually get buried under additional layers of snow and turn into ice.

The information contained in snowflakes can be very informative for scientists. They can analyze it by studying "ice cores," which are long cylinders of ice that are drilled out from deep in the ice sheet. The cores are typically about 4 to 5 inches wide and have been pulled from as far as 1.7 miles deep. That far down, the ice is about 1.2 million years old. Ice cores help scientists learn what Earth was like in the past and how it has changed.



Using AI to identify dinosaur tracks

Scientists developed an app called DinoTracker that uses artificial intelligence (AI, when a computer imitates human learning) to identify fossilized dinosaur footprints. Footprints are the most commonly found traces of dinosaurs, but determining which creature left an individual footprint can be a challenge.

The team that built DinoTracker trained the AI by showing it about 2,000 dinosaur footprints.

Many of the tracks were previously identified by scientists, and some came from modern birds, which are descended from dinosaurs. Then the team gave the AI millions of variations on those footprints to learn from.

The AI analyzed all the footprints and identified eight key features for

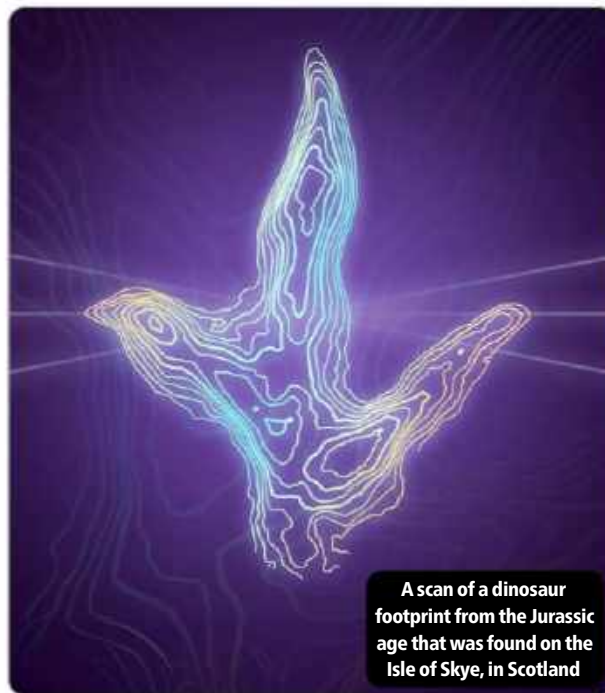
telling them apart. These included how far apart the toes were spread, where the heel was, and how much weight was placed on different parts of the foot.

When users upload a photo or outline of a footprint to DinoTracker, it identifies the seven footprints most similar to it and what dinosaur is thought to have made those footprints. The team tested the app by showing it dinosaur tracks that were already identified.

DinoTracker matched human experts' identifications about 90% of the time.

DinoTracker is available to the public for free. The app is a good research tool, said Paige dePolo, one of the scientists who developed it. "More excitingly, it's a tool for curious children...to take outside when they are exploring."

HUGE FEET
The world's largest known dino footprints were left by sauropods in Australia and are more than 5 feet long.



A scan of a dinosaur footprint from the Jurassic age that was found on the Isle of Skye, in Scotland



Grandparents and grandchildren help each other.

Childcare gives grandparents a boost

Grandparents who care for their grandchildren have better brain function as they age, according to a new study.

Researchers in the Netherlands studied nearly 3,000 grandparents ages 50 or older. Participants completed tests and questionnaires three times between 2016 and 2022 and indicated whether they had taken care of a grandchild in the past year. Grandparents noted what they did, such as helped with homework, drove the kids to school or activities,

prepared food, played with them, or cared for them when they were sick.

Grandparents who spent time with grandkids had better memory and language skills regardless of how often they were together or what they did. Grandmothers showed the improvements for the longest length of time.

More studies will show whether other factors make a difference, like how family members interact and how much happiness grandparents get from caring for grandchildren.



A food allergen detection device



Allergen Alert

A portable device could save lives by detecting food allergens and gluten within minutes. Allergen Alert, created by scientists in France, made its debut at the 2026 Consumer Electronics Show. It currently tests for gluten and dairy, with more allergens coming in 2028.

Users place food in a pouch and insert it into the device, which analyzes the sample using lab-grade technology. Allergen Alert can be used by people with allergies and by restaurants, schools, and other places that serve food to test ingredients and detect cross-contamination.



Photos of the week

INTERNATIONAL
DOG
PHOTOGRAPHY
AWARDS
FINALISTS



On the ball

A husky gets ready to pounce in this photo taken by Sylvain Langler and Rudy Anthoine.



Role play

This *Star Wars*-inspired picture was created by Jane Thompson.



MIA TEPELEA, SYLVAIN LANGLER AND RUDY ANTHOINE; KATE BROCKMAN; JIE HUAPU; JANE THOMPSON 16

Photos of the week



Furry feast

Katie Brockman created this image by combining multiple photos.



Taking flight

Barbara Cesari took this shot of a dog jumping to catch a Frisbee.



Stand together

Mia Tepelea captured this photo of two dogs playing.



Historic finish to the

On February 22, the 2026 Milan Cortina Winter Olympics came to an end after more than two weeks of competition in Italy (see story on page 3). Norway finished at the top of the medal table, continuing its strong history in winter sports. It led all countries with a total of 41 medals, 18 of which were gold.

Team USA finished with a total of 33 medals, the second-highest number of any nation. This included 12 gold medals, the most ever for the US in a Winter Olympics. In women's events, US athletes earned 17 medals, including six golds. In men's competition, they won 12 medals, including four golds. In mixed-gender events, the total was four medals, including two golds.

Many of Team USA's most exciting moments came in the final days of the Olympics. Here are some of the highlights.

DAY 11

On February 17, the US won two silver medals. In speed skating, the trio of Casey Dawson, Ethan Cepuran, and Emery Lehman claimed one of them in the men's team pursuit event, a head-to-head race. The US team dominated the Chinese team in their semifinals matchup, beating them by 7.93



The US women's ice hockey team

COOL FACT
In Olympic ice hockey, the US and Canada have met in seven women's and three men's gold-medal games.

seconds, but a team from Italy came away with the gold in the final.

Team USA's other silver that day was won by Mac Forehand in the men's freestyle skiing big air competition. In the final, he landed a jump that had never been done before. He was happy with his performance, saying afterward, "This is the stuff I've wanted to do since I was a young kid, going out there and pushing the sport as hard as I can and trying to win medals."

DAY 12

Alpine skier Mikaela Shiffrin of the US, one of the best slalom skiers in the sport's history, helped solidify

her legacy by winning gold in the women's slalom. In the event, she beat silver medalist Camille Rast of Switzerland by 1.50 seconds. In this season's World Cup competitions, Rast was the only skier who had beaten Shiffrin.

The US star was under extra pressure to medal at this year's Games because she did not medal in any of her six events at the 2022 Winter Olympics. She now has three career Olympic golds, a feat no other female American skier has accomplished. In 2014, Shiffrin became the youngest Olympic slalom champion after winning gold at age 18, and after her triumph this year, she is the oldest American woman to earn an Alpine gold.

US cross-country skiers Ben Ogden and Gus Schumacher had success that day too, winning silver in the men's team sprint event. Meanwhile, American snowboarder Jake Canter won a bronze medal in

slopestyle. Nine years ago, at age 13, he suffered a traumatic brain injury, nearly died, and had to relearn how to walk and talk. "I wanted to make that 13-year-old me proud," he said after his competition. "So I really hope I did."

DAY 13

After US speed skater Jordan Stolz won his third medal of the Games, a silver in the men's 1,500-meter race, Team USA had two thrilling victories.

In women's ice hockey, the US faced archrivals Team Canada in the gold-medal game and won, 2-1, in overtime. Canada had a 1-0 lead with two minutes remaining in the third period, but the US tied it up after US captain Hilary Knight tipped in a shot by her teammate Laila Edwards. The game went to a sudden-death, 3-on-3 overtime period, and just over four minutes into the action, Team USA's Megan Keller scored what is known as a golden goal, clinching the Olympic title.



HIGH SPEED
One world record and nine Olympic records were broken at this year's Winter Games.

Mikaela Shiffrin

Jake Canter



Winter Olympics

Knight was playing in her fifth Olympics, and her last goal turned her into the all-time leading Olympic goal scorer and points scorer (goals plus assists) in US women's hockey history. Edwards, who made her Olympic debut this year, is now the first Black American hockey player in US history to win Olympic gold.

Not long after that game ended, US figure skater

Alysa Liu delivered a spectacular free skate performance that helped her win the women's singles gold. Her victory broke a 20-year Olympic medal drought for Americans in that event. Liu had retired from figure skating after the Beijing Olympics in 2022, but she returned to skating in 2024. She entered the free skate in third place and said after winning, "I was peak happiness when I was out there on the ice."

Alysa Liu



became the second American man to win an individual gold at this year's Games. Ferreira had previously won a bronze at the 2022 Olympics and a silver at the 2018 Games. Another Team USA medalist that day was Corinne Stoddard, who earned the bronze in the women's short track speed skating 1,500-meter event.

DAY 15

The trio of Kaila Kuhn, Connor Curran, and Christopher Lillis helped Team USA capture back-to-back Olympic titles in freestyle skiing mixed team aerobics. In their impressive gold-medal performance, they outscored the silver medalists from Switzerland by nearly 30 points.

Other Americans who earned medals that day were speed skater Mia Manganello, the bronze winner in the women's mass start event, and Kaillie Humphries and Jasmine Jones, who earned a bronze in the two-woman bobsled, beating the fourth-place finishers by .15 seconds.



Alex Ferreira

DAY 16

Team USA ended the Games with a second historic ice hockey game. This time, the men's team faced off against their rivals from Canada and won, 2-1, in overtime. It had been 46 years since the US won Olympic gold in men's hockey. The new victory also took place on the exact anniversary of the 1980 Olympic team's upset of the Soviet Union in a semifinal game that became known as the "Miracle on Ice."

All the players on this year's US and Canadian teams were NHL (National Hockey League) stars. Canada dominated the game, but US

goaltender Connor Hellebuyck made a remarkable 41 saves to keep his team in it. Jack Hughes scored the golden goal about two minutes into the sudden-death, 3-on-3 overtime period. Four days earlier, his brother Quinn scored the game-winning overtime goal in the quarterfinals.

After the gold-medal win, the US team honored Johnny Gaudreau, an NHL All-Star who died in an accident in 2024 with his brother, Matthew, another NHL player. The athletes skated around the rink holding a Gaudreau jersey and brought Johnny's two young children onto the ice for photos with the team.

DAY 14

On February 20, freestyle skier Alex Ferreira won the halfpipe final and



The US men's hockey team

An unexpected star



On February 18, during an early qualifying round of a cross-country skiing event, a local Czechoslovakian wolfdog named Nazgul (above) broke out of his doghouse and ended up on the race course. As he crossed the finish line, he was photographed as if he were a competitor.



Arts and entertainment

WOW!

The world's largest beaver dam is in Canada's Wood Buffalo National Park. It stretches about 2,790 feet, which is nearly the length of eight football fields.



Hoppers heads to theaters

Disney-Pixar's new film is a comedy-adventure set in the world of beavers.

One way scientists study wildlife is by sending robots that look like animals into habitats to record life there. That creative use of technology inspired Disney and Pixar's new animated film *Hoppers*, a comedy adventure arriving in theaters on March 6.

The film revolves around a 19-year-old girl, Mabel (voiced by Piper Curda), who is chosen to test a device that lets her "hop" her consciousness into a robotic beaver. It allows her to live with the animals and communicate with them. When the beavers learn about a human threat to their land, she helps them protect it.

Hoppers was directed by Daniel Chong, who told *The Week Junior* that audiences will be able to learn from Mabel's story and her efforts to make a difference in the world. "Often when you're young, it's really hard to feel heard," he said. "But if you can find a community that cares about things as much as you do and can support you, it's a great start."

To ensure the on-screen beavers looked and acted like real ones, Chong and his team worked with beaver expert Emily Fairfax, an ecohydrologist (someone who studies water and ecology). She talked to them about beaver habitats and

the ways the animals behave, reviewed early storyboards, and advised the team on details such as how beavers use their tails and what types of animals live in different environments. She even took the art team on a field trip to wetlands in Colorado and Wyoming. They had to wade in ponds and stay safe from moose, but they were able to watch beavers at work on dams and see firsthand how they build their world.



Piper Curda

Fairfax appreciates that *Hoppers* has given her a chance to share her beaver knowledge with a large number of people. "I'm most excited for audiences to learn how important beavers are in the ecosystem and how powerful they are in the face of disaster," she told *The Week Junior*. "Many other plants and

animals depend on them to survive, and the habitats they make are uniquely resistant to drought and flood and fire. Those ideas come through loud and clear in the film."

Chong said *Hoppers* is "a story of how we are all part of the same ecosystem with nature." He hopes moviegoers also forge bonds with one another when they see the film in theaters. "It's a very connective experience to laugh, cry, or scream with other people," he said.

Interesting facts about beavers



Beavers are large, semi-aquatic rodents with stocky bodies, webbed hind feet that help them swim, and a flat, scaly tail that helps them steer. The animals tap their tails on a surface when they want to signal danger.

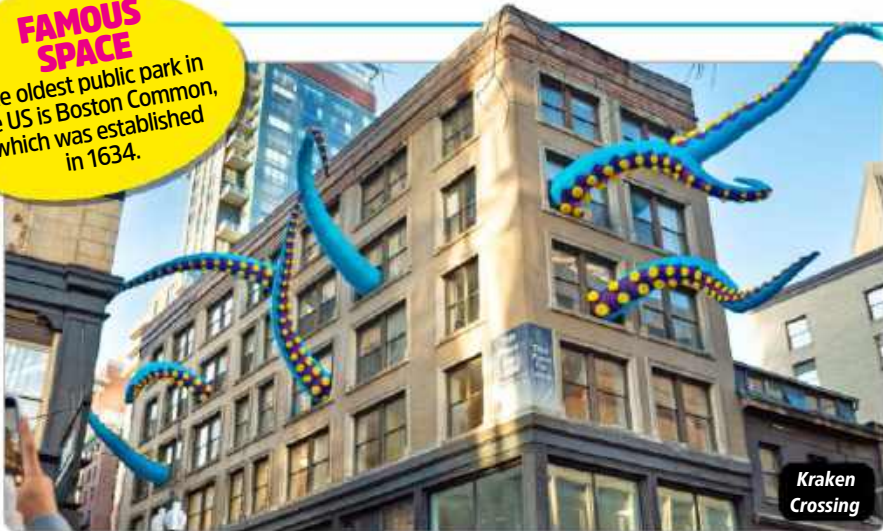
Beavers are known as "nature's engineers" because of the dams and lodges they build with materials such as sticks, tree branches, and stones. They also use mud, which they pack down with their paws, beaver expert Emily Fairfax told *The Week Junior*.

She is excited for people to see *Hoppers* and discover other fun facts about beavers. Beaver parents help their babies learn to swim, for example, and beavers sit on their tail like it's a cushion. Although the animals have orange teeth in real life, they're off-white in the film to make them stand out from their bodies.



FAMOUS SPACE

The oldest public park in the US is Boston Common, which was established in 1634.



Kraken Crossing

Outdoor art exhibited in Boston

Downtown Boston, Massachusetts, has been turned into an outdoor art gallery as part of an annual event known as Winteractive. It features 18 large-scale sculptures and interactive art, including sea-inspired seesaws, which have been installed on buildings and sidewalks. They will be on display through March 29.

Winteractive is overseen by the Downtown Boston Alliance, an organization that has a goal of encouraging people to get outside during the chilly months and support local businesses. This year is the third edition of the event, and artists from around the world have their work showcased.

Among the pieces on display are *Big Other*, a collection of enormous emoji-like eyes that have been placed on several buildings, and *Kraken Crossing*, a set of inflatable tentacles that

come out of a building's windows. Visitors to the area may also come across *Artificial Humans*, 12 life-size glowing statues of people looking down at their hands, as if they are holding phones. The piece encourages people to think about how much time they spend on devices. *The Word on the Street*, meanwhile, is a set of street



The Word on the Street

signs with motivational messages such as "You Are Enough" and "Do Your Best." The work was created by artist Scott Froschauer, who said he wants to help people become "present, open, [and] aware."

Above all, organizers say the event is using the power of art to boost people's moods during the gray winter. "It's just something to keep you going, to try to bring a smile to your face in a moment when things might be a little bit bleak," Maria Noguera, a planner at the Alliance, told the digital magazine *The Scope*.



3 MORE PICKS TO ENJOY THIS WEEK



WATCH: MIRACULOUS WORLD: TOKYO STELLAR FORCE

This one-hour special is an anime-style spin-off of the hit series *Miraculous*. It follows Marinette, a teenager also known as the superhero Ladybug, and her friend Kagami as they team up in Tokyo, Japan, to stop a villain. A *Miraculous Stellar Force* series will premiere in 2027. (Disney+)



CLICK: CLUES BY SAM

This online logic puzzle has a new board with 20 emoji characters each day, and the challenge is to use hints to identify who is a criminal and who is innocent. The trickiness level varies daily, and you can't solve the puzzle with completely random guesses, but the site includes online tutorials that can help. (cluesbysam.com)



LISTEN: THE ZOOQUARIUM PODCAST

Artist Mike Bennett and marine biologist Chanel Hason are the hosts of this show about animals. They answer questions from kids and chat with experts. Topics have included the way sea otters hold their breath underwater and why toucans have giant beaks. (Major podcast platforms)



READER RECOMMENDS



Vampirina: Teenage Vampire (Disney+)

"This sitcom is a show for fans of magic or fantasy. It's based on a children's picture book series, and it follows Vampirina 'Vee' Hauntley, a young vampire. She wants to be a singer, so she disguises herself as a human in order to attend a performing arts boarding school, Wilson Hall. When her best friends discover the truth about her identity, keeping her secret becomes even harder. Vee and her friends end up in many tricky situations where Vee almost gets found out. It's exciting to watch and wonder if Vee's identity will ever get fully exposed." Lily, 9, and Abby, 10, California

Do you have a film or TV show to recommend to other kids? Send your review to hello@theweekjunior.com.



Book club

THIS WEEK'S BOOK

Magnitude

By Jennifer A. Nielsen

It's 1906 and a powerful earthquake just struck San Francisco. Buildings are collapsing all around Cora and her new friend Chi, whom she met minutes before when two boys tried to steal her bike. The girls become trapped underground. Not only is rubble on top of them, but a broken pipe may eventually flood their space.

Running out of air, they try to wiggle free and end up dropping further into an old ship buried beneath the street. While looking for items that may help them escape, Cora secretly slips a pouch of gold coins into her pocket so she can pay off her family's debt. They also discover a harpoon cannon, which they fire to clear through some of the rubble so their screams for help can be heard.

Oliver, who was Cora's best friend until their families started feuding, rescues them, but their perilous adventure has only just begun. Fires are blazing all around the city as Cora and Chi set off to find their families with Oliver's help. It's a race against the clock.

Told from Cora's point of view, this historical fiction novel, based on the real-life San Francisco earthquake of 1906, will leave you on the edge of your seat. Ages 8–12

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS FOR YOUR BOOK CLUB

Should Oliver have remained friends with Cora despite their family's squabbles?

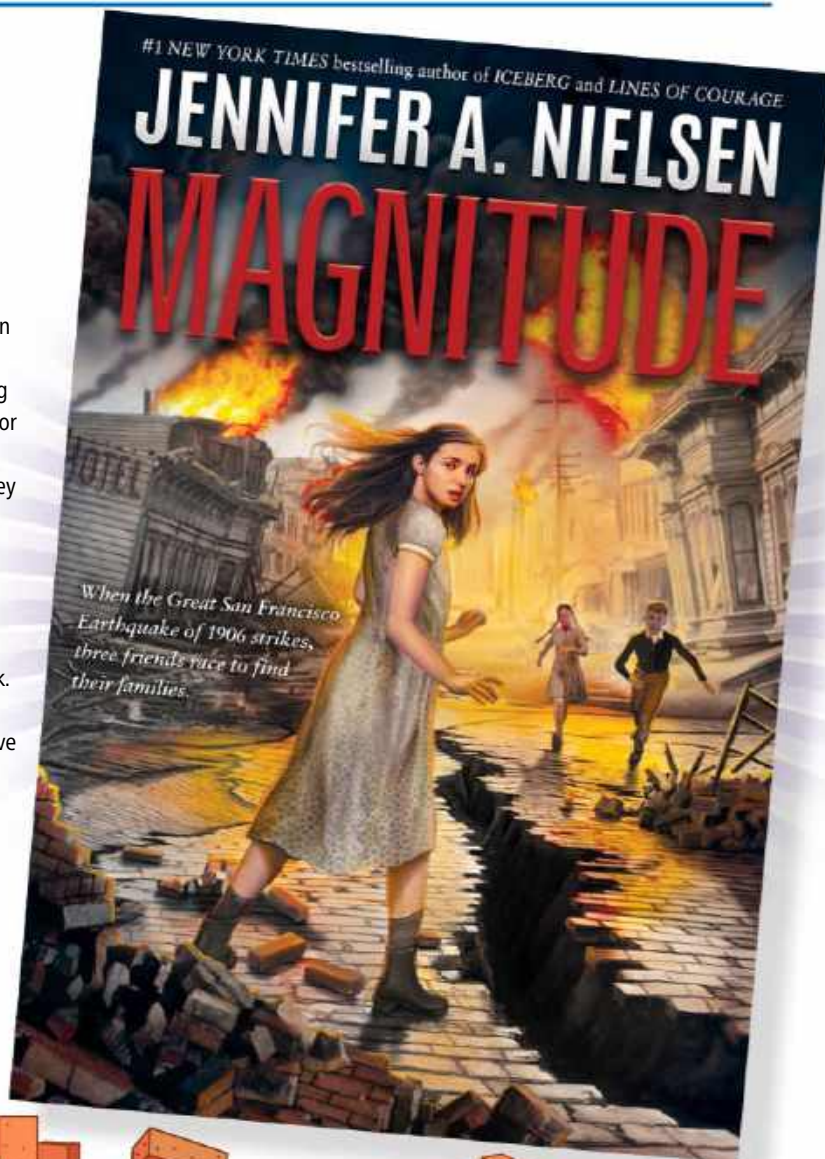
How does discrimination against Chi and other Chinese residents of San Francisco make you feel?

If you were Cora, would you have taken the coins?

How were the events in San Francisco after the earthquake worse than the natural disaster itself?

In which part of the story did you feel the most tension?

What do you think will happen to Cora, Oliver, and Chi in the future?



Find your next great read

If you liked...



The Bad Beginning

By Lemony Snicket

In the first book of *A Series of Unfortunate Events*, three siblings unexpectedly lose their parents. Left with

unfit guardians and pursued by a villain, the offbeat orphans unravel mysteries about their family's past. Ages 8–12

You might like...



The Problem Children

By Natalie Lloyd

Seven goth siblings, each named after a day of the week, have to leave their house after it explodes. The

kids move into their grandpa's mansion, leading to quirky, fun-to-read adventures in the series' three books. Ages 8–12



Guess the book this quote comes from

"It's been my experience that you can nearly always enjoy things if you make up your mind firmly that you will."

Hint: This 1908 novel, featuring a title character who has braids in her hair, takes place in Canada.

Answer: *Anne of Green Gables* by Lucy Maud Montgomery. Elderly siblings send for an orphan boy to help on their farm. Due to a mix-up, they are sent Anne, who convinces them to let her stay.



THIS WEEK'S AUTHOR

Jennifer A. Nielsen

New York Times best-selling author Jennifer A. Nielsen writes young adult and middle-grade fantasy, historical fiction, and adventure novels. Among the series she's written are *The Ascendance* books, which follow an orphan named Sage who is forced to impersonate a missing prince.

What made you want to write about the 1906 San Francisco earthquake?

My great-grandparents were both born in San Francisco, about a year or two after the big earthquake, so there's a family connection. I had just written about the Titanic for my novel *Iceberg*, which is a survival story, and I loved researching that. This event in San Francisco just seemed like such a natural place for me to go.

What are some themes of this book?

There is a lot to say about friendship and how powerful and important it is to have friends you can trust and friends who have got your back. There is also something there about continuing to keep going, even when it's hard. There's always a way to take the next step. Other themes are certainly about courage, honor, and the need to protect everybody, not just people like you.

How would you describe Cora?

She is just grit and someone I would love to be like. She is willing to do what it takes, and I really like that about her.



If you weren't a writer, what do you think you would do instead?

I live in a small town, and I would open a theater there, where I would teach theater to kids. I would still be telling stories, but the stories would be performed rather than written.

If you could travel to one historical period, what would it be and why?

World War II (1939–1945). There's a reason we call the people of that era our greatest generation. The more I learn about it, the more I realize that everybody, in some way, was doing something to try to fight off this incredible evil.

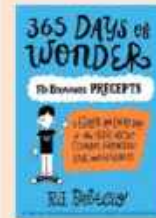
Do you have a preferred cold-weather drink?

Honey and chamomile tea is my go-to, and it warms me from the inside every time!



Books filled with acts of kindness

Celebrate Read Across America's theme of kindness—and see page 24!



365 Days of Wonder: Mr. Browne's Precepts

By R.J. Palacio

The memorable teacher Mr. Browne in the novel *Wonder* taught his class

precepts (rules of action), including "When given the choice between being right and being kind, choose kind." This book has daily precepts from authors, notable figures, and children who have read *Wonder*. One child's precept: "Love a little more each day." Ages 8+



Because of Winn-Dixie

By Kate DiCamillo

A chain reaction of kindness springs from a series of small actions by Opal, a 10-year-old who

moves to Florida with her father and adopts a dog she finds in a supermarket. As Opal works through her own problems, including the fact that her mother left her family, she realizes that being kind makes her more resilient and brings joy to others. Ages 8–12



A Place at the Table

By Saadia Faruqi and Laura Shovan

Sixth-graders Sara and Elizabeth meet at a cooking class and bond as they navigate difficult

issues like racism and family illness. Sara is Pakistani American and Elizabeth is Jewish, and the story showcases the power of understanding and empathy across cultures. Delicious recipes you can make at home are sprinkled throughout the book. Ages 10–14



Reader recommends



The Lost Year: A Survival Story of the Ukrainian Famine

By Katherine Marsh

"This book is from multiple perspectives. In modern times, a boy named Matthew finds a photo of three girls: his great-grandmother, a girl named Helen, and a girl named Nadiya. In the 1930s in Soviet Ukraine, a girl named Mila lives with her father and her nanny, Dasha. Mila is searching for Nadiya, her cousin, who is starving and barely alive. How are these timelines related? Read to find out." Harper, 10, Washington

Do you have a book to recommend? We want to hear about it! With an adult's help, please send your review to hello@theweekjunior.com.

Find out more about *The Week Junior*

Book Club and check out our previous

titles at kids.theweekjunior.com/bookclub.





How to...

BIG IDEA

Read Across America was launched in 1998 by the National Education Association.



Go places with reading

Embark on an adventure—and celebrate National Reading Month—with books.

Read Across America Day takes place on March 2, which also kicks off National Reading Month. One of the goals of Read Across America (RAA), a celebration of reading sponsored by the National Education Association, is to introduce children to diverse and inclusive books with characters they can relate to and worlds that are different from their own. Here's how you can take part in the celebration.

Host a book swap

Ask a few friends or family members to think about a middle-grade book that introduced them to new genres and voices and that they would be willing to loan to someone else. Then host a book swap. You can lay the books out on a table and give everyone a chance to read the plot summary on the back or check out the first few pages. Try making the swap extra fun with snacks, like a bowl of “book worms” (gummy worms). Everyone can go home at the end of the event with one or more new books.

Read as a group

Since reading can also be a joyful experience to share with others, another idea is to plan a

“read-in,” which is an event where a group can read together. Or ask a teacher to hold the read-in in a classroom. Ask everyone to bring a book to the event and to read a short excerpt aloud from it. This is a great way to spark conversations, and you can also make notes about books you'd like to add to your own reading list.

Explore this year's theme

The 2026 theme for Read Across America is kindness, so this is a great time to choose titles with that focus. You can find a few options in the orange box on page 23. Others include *Wonder* by R.J. Palacio, *The Invisible Boy* by Trudy Ludwig, *Stargirl* by Jerry Spinelli, and *Each Kindness* by Jacqueline Woodson.



See the world through books!

Reflect on what you've read

You might enjoy keeping track of the books you've read in a journal, on a device, or by filling out the form on the next page. You can think about what stood out to you about the story, setting, or characters and reflect on what you learned. For more reading suggestions, see the “50 books, 50 states” box at right.

50 books, 50 states



You can read across the US with the books on our two separate lists titled “Read Across America,” featuring 50 books for 50 states. That's 100 books to choose from!

One fun challenge would be to read four or more books that take place in different states. Pick any states you wish. You could choose books that take place in the state where you live, states you may have visited, or places you are curious about.

The lists of 50 books for 50 states can be found on *The Week Junior's* Book Club page at kids.theweekjunior.com/bookclub. Use the form on the next page to write your reviews. You can find more forms at kids.theweekjunior.com/activities.

Read your way across the country

Enjoy four books that are set in any state and use this form to rate and review them!

First name _____

Age _____ State _____

Book #1

Title _____

Author _____

Rating  (1 star is the lowest, 3 is the highest)

The state where the book takes place _____

Your review in one word _____

Your longer review if you wish _____

Book #2

Title _____

Author _____

Rating  (1 star is the lowest, 3 is the highest)

The state where the book takes place _____

Your review in one word _____

Your longer review if you wish _____

Book #3

Title _____

Author _____

Rating  (1 star is the lowest, 3 is the highest)

The state where the book takes place _____

Your review in one word _____

Your longer review if you wish _____

Book #4

Title _____

Author _____

Rating  (1 star is the lowest, 3 is the highest)

The state where the book takes place _____

Your review in one word _____

Your longer review if you wish _____



Puzzles



Word ladder

To change the word DOOR into the word KNOB, use each clue to fill in a word that is only one letter different from the word before it. If you get stuck, try solving from the bottom up.



D O O R

The feeling that a bad situation is coming

□ □ □ □

Onomatopoeia (sound effect word) for an explosion

□ □ □ □

Item that Italy's shape is said to resemble

□ □ □ □

Stuff on a chimney sweep's clothing

□ □ □ □

"Give it a ____" ("Give it a try")

□ □ □ □

Production performed on a stage

□ □ □ □

It may pile up in a drift or bank

□ □ □ □

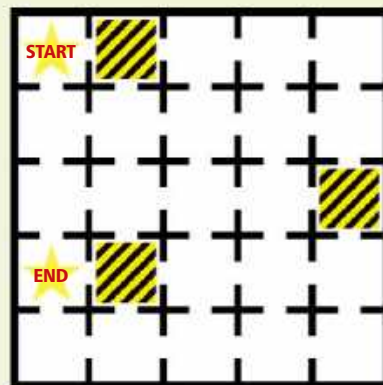
Be certain of

□ □ □ □

K N O B

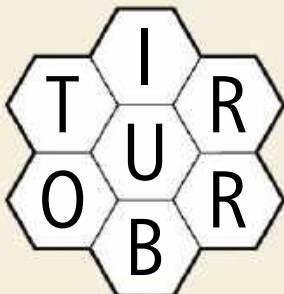
DO NOT ENTER

Draw one continuous path from START to END that goes through every box except the ones containing obstacles. Your path may not cross itself, and there is only one solution.



STEPPING STONES

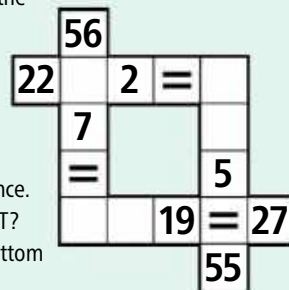
Each figure hides a seven-letter kind of Mexican food. To find each one, start anywhere and move in an unbroken path through letters that share a border (no jumping!), using each letter once.



ANSWERS
CAN BE
FOUND ON
PAGE 29.

Crossmath

Fill each empty box with a number or a mathematical symbol (+, -, ×, or ÷) to complete the equations across and down. A symbol can be used more than once. (NEED A HINT? Check the bottom of the page.)



Spot the difference

These two pictures of Yellowstone National Park's entrance appear to be the same, but take a closer look. There are actually five differences. Can you see them?





Ooh-la-
lobster!



Feast at France's fancy buffet

France may be known for its charming cafés, but one of its most popular restaurants is an all-you-can-eat buffet. When it opened in 1989, Les Grands Buffets was the only eatery of its kind in the country. Offering traditional fare like foie gras and steak tartare in a dining room that looks like a 19th-century palace, it also has a seven-tier lobster fountain and the world's largest selection of cheeses. About 400,000 diners eat there every year. If they save room, they can choose from about 50 different desserts.

Pretty fly for
an old guy



A life of songs and snuggles

Sonny the cockatiel hasn't gone gray—he was born this color. Named the world's oldest living cockatiel last fall, Sonny recently celebrated his 33rd birthday. That's more than twice the average for his species, which typically lives 10 to 15 years. Sonny has spent his days with Janet Reicher and her family in Illinois, showing off his talents for learning words and whistling tunes. Reicher said the reasons for her pet's long life include nutritious, home-cooked meals and "lots of love." "He is a snuggler," she told ABC News.

She's really
on a roll.



Piano music on the move

Chloe Marie Aston's music is truly moving. The UK-based musician plays a blue electric piano attached to a bicycle, which she pedals from place to place as she performs in public spaces in exchange for tips. In February, she broke the world record for doing this in the most towns and cities. But even after traveling to 190 different points on the map, the piano biker is not done pedaling. She told Guinness World Records she eventually hopes to visit every city and town in the UK.

Real or
fake?



Is it a
freeze-way?

Driving on a road made of ice

There's a silver lining to northern Europe's chilly winter weather, at least for drivers in Estonia. Residents of the small island of Hiiumaa often take the ferry to nearby Saaremaa for school or errands. But lately, temperatures have been so low that the sea between the islands has frozen over. Now officials have opened a 12.5-mile "ice road" so people can drive across it. Workers monitor the thickness of the ice and make sure it's smooth and safe enough for travel. Is this story true, or would it crack under pressure?*

*Real! For the first time in eight years, experts have found the ice thick enough to support cars. Drivers must maintain a safe speed across a marked corridor. "The road was pretty good," said one motorist. "It was easy to ride."



Your turn

Editor's note



Did you watch the Winter Olympics (p3, 18)? Judging from the photos at right, sent to us as the Games were beginning, I'm guessing you did! If you did watch, which event or performance did you enjoy most? I couldn't possibly choose just one! So many of the athletes were so impressive, and several made history in their sport. Team USA also made history by bringing home 12 gold medals—the most our nation has ever earned in a Winter Olympics. Just as impressive as the performances that resulted in a gold, silver, or bronze medal on the podium was the sportsmanship displayed by those who didn't achieve everything they had hoped for. Even without a medal, they showed talent, determination, courage, and grace—making them winners as well. Now that the Olympics are over, we turn our attention to the next major global sports competition: the Paralympics! You can find a preview of the action on pages 12–13.

Andrea Barbalich
Editorial Director



CHARITY OF THE WEEK



Girls Inc.

This organization's goal is to inspire and empower girls to be strong, smart, and bold. It is the longest-running girls' leadership group, reaching millions of girls a year. Girls Inc. provides after-school and summer programming, including arts and crafts programs and leadership classes. It encourages girls to advocate for themselves so they can become self-confident individuals. Find out more at girlsinc.org.

girls
inc.

YOUR FANTASTIC OLYMPIC CELEBRATIONS!



▲ “I celebrated the 2026 Winter Olympics by making the torch cupcakes! Thanks for the recipe!”
Zoe, 11, Idaho



◀ “I made the Olympic t-shirt from *The Week Junior*, and I wore it while watching the Winter Olympics.”
Merritt, 9, California



◀ “We had all the supplies at home to make the hockey rink game, and it was so much fun!” Henry, 11, and Jesse, 10, Colorado



READER RECOMMENDS

Vote for your favorite books!

Have you read any books you've enjoyed so much you wish all kids knew about them? Contribute to our “50 Books Kids Love Most” list for 2026! The list, with quotes from readers, will be published in *The Week Junior* in June. We're looking for at least 100 kids to fill out our voting form. If you'd like to vote, have an adult email us at hello@theweekjunior.com with Books Kids Love in the subject line, and we'll send the form to you. Happy reading!



THE WEEK
Junior

IT'S YOUR TURN

Email your news, views, and photos to hello@theweekjunior.com.

Your turn



Thank you to everyone who sent us photos of the Olympic-themed recipes and crafts they made from Issue 302 of *The Week Junior*! A selection of submissions is shown here. If you're preparing to watch the Paralympics, which start on March 6, we'd love to hear about it. Have an adult email your photos and stories to hello@theweekjunior.com.



▲ "We had a blast making the hockey rink game to kick off the Winter Olympics." **Charlie, 9, and Sloane, 11, Texas**

▼ "The flaming torch cupcakes were really good, and we ate them while watching the opening ceremony." **Bennett, 9, Oregon**



▲ "The Olympic brownie bites were a great dessert." **Inez, 10, and Carmen, 8, California**

▼ "It was so cold here that we froze the hockey rink game outside." **Elliot, 9, New Jersey**



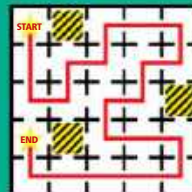
Puzzle answers (from page 26)

Word ladder

D O O R
D O O M
B O O M
B O O T
S O O T
S H O T
S H O W
S N O W
K N O W
K N O B

Stepping stones

burrito, fajitas



$$\begin{array}{r} 56 \\ 22 \div 2 = 11 \\ 7 \quad \times \\ = \quad 5 \\ 8 + 19 = 27 \\ 55 \end{array}$$



Quiz answers (from page 30)

1 Nintxndo 2 c) Fruit fly 3 Falsx. It was in Nxw York City. 4 Canada 5 a) Producx
6 b) Xlphaba 7 Trux 8 b) Tastx 9 Falsx. Humans spxak fastxr than dogs vocalizx.
10 a) Baramos 11 Trux 12 Bxyoncé 13 a) Xarthquaxx 14 Trux 15 Poozxum

We want to hear from you! To have your letters, photos, nominations, recommendations, or ideas considered for inclusion in the magazine, please include your first name, age, and state with your submission. By emailing your submission to us, you give *The Week Junior* consent to publish it in the magazine and online. Please get your parent/guardian's permission before sending anything to us.



Quiz

How much of this week's news can you remember?

1 A new study found that horses can detect which human emotion by smell?

- a) Anger
b) Fear
c) Sadness

a ☐ b ☐ c ☐

2 What actress recently received a star on the Hollywood Walk of Fame?

3 When were the first Winter Paralympics held?

- a) 1948 b) 1960 c) 1976

a ☐ b ☐ c ☐

4 True or false? Big Basin Redwoods is the oldest state park in California.

True ☐ False ☐

5 Which major entertainment award propelled Steven Spielberg to EGOT status?

- a) Grammy b) Oscar c) Tony

a ☐ b ☐ c ☐

6 What is the name of the app that uses artificial intelligence to identify fossilized dinosaur footprints?

7 Roads are being closed to protect tortoises in which desert?

- a) Sonora b) Kalahari
c) Mojave

a ☐ b ☐ c ☐

8 True or false? The movie *Hoppers* is about a girl who transfers her consciousness to a robotic rabbit.

True ☐ False ☐



9 Who scored the goal that clinched the gold medal for the US women's hockey team at the Winter Olympics?

- a) Hilary Knight
b) Megan Keller
c) Taylor Heise

a ☐ b ☐ c ☐

10 True or false? The continent of Antarctica is the size of the US and Mexico combined.

True ☐ False ☐

11 What is the name of the outdoor art exhibit in Boston that aims to cheer people up in winter?

12 The novel *Magnitude* is about a real earthquake in which California city?

- a) Los Angeles
b) San Diego
c) San Francisco

a ☐ b ☐ c ☐

13 The closing ceremony for the 2026 Milan Cortina Games was held at what ancient amphitheater?

14 True or false? The world's largest selection of cheeses is offered at a restaurant in Spain.

True ☐ False ☐

15 What animal was photographed crossing the finish line during a cross-country skiing race on February 18?

- a) Dog b) Cat c) Goat

a ☐ b ☐ c ☐

THE WEEK Junior

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REPTILE RAINBOW

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